

THE WEIGHT OF QUIET

Written by

Tendai

Working title. One continuous shot, no cuts.
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FADE IN:

EXT. LAKE DISTRICT COTTAGE / FELLS - DUSK

Black. Then the grey ridge of mountains against darker sky.

The camera hangs high above a stone cottage. A single downstairs window burns gold.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. It snakes down through the cold, tilting toward the light the way a thing comes home.

Closer. The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open.

INT. COTTAGE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Into the middle of it.

The room is already loud. Two mugs on the side table. One steaming. One dead cold. A chair pushed out at a wrong angle. This has been going a while.

MAYA, 30s, still in her coat because she never got the chance to take it off. She argues the way she works: fast, precise, building a case, giving no ground.

JAMES, 30s, halfway across the room. He argues the way he leaves a room: sideways, quiet, already half out of every sentence.

The camera settles off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. Something in him eases, a body that has decided it isn't alone. It is the wrong moment for it.

MAYA

No. Finish it. You opened your mouth, so finish it.

JAMES

I wasn't going to say anything.

MAYA

You were about to. Then you left. Say it.

JAMES

There's nothing to--

MAYA

There is always something. There is

always a room you're standing in
that I don't get let into.

JAMES
(flat, tired of the
script)
Here we go.

MAYA
Don't. Don't "here we go" me like
I'm the weather.

He turns from her. Crosses to the window. Shoves it open.
Cold pours in.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Are you serious.

JAMES
It's hot in here.

MAYA
It is not hot. It's me. I'm the
thing that's too much in the room.
Just say that instead.

JAMES
I didn't say that.

MAYA
You opened a window in November.
You would rather freeze in a field
than stand in a warm room with me
for one more minute.

He slams it shut. The glass jumps in the frame.

JAMES
There. Happy?

MAYA
(a laugh with nothing in
it)
Do I look happy to you? Does this
look like a happy face?

JAMES
Tell me what you want. Give me the
actual words and I will do it.

MAYA
I want you to look at me.

JAMES
I am looking at you.

MAYA
For one whole sentence. Start to
finish. Without going...
(her hand flails at the
empty air beside him)
...wherever it is you go.

JAMES
I am right here. I have been
standing here the whole time.

MAYA
You made two coffees this morning.

JAMES
(exhausted)
Oh my god.

MAYA
Two. I watched you.

JAMES
I miscounted. It's a cup of coffee.

MAYA
You do not miscount. You count my
drinks. You counted them at dinner,
one, two, three, I watched you do
the little sum in your head--

JAMES
Because you were--

MAYA
I was WHAT. Say it. For once in
your life land the hit instead of
carrying it out of the room still
in your hand.

He stops backing away. Turns. His voice drops, and it gets
worse.

JAMES
(quiet, precise, cruel)
You perform. You host the argument.
You booked the cottage, you booked
the fight, you put us in your
calendar in a little colour. Who
does that. Who schedules the night
their marriage falls--

MAYA
At least I show up to it.

JAMES

You show up to run it.

MAYA
Somebody has to be in the room.
Because you are not. You have not
been in one single room with me in
months.

JAMES
I am IN the room.

MAYA
Then look at me.

She crosses the space and takes his face in both hands.
Forces it to hers.

MAYA (CONT'D)
There. Is it that hard. Am I that
hard to look at.

He pulls his head free. Steps back.

JAMES
(low, a warning)
Don't grab me.

MAYA
Then stay in your own face. You
leave your own eyes, do you know
that. Mid-word. Every single time.
You go.

He is breathing hard. And then he cannot help it. His head
tips. A fraction. Toward the space beside him. A listening.

She watches it happen. In real time. It takes the fight out
of her and puts something worse in its place.

MAYA (CONT'D)
(quiet, wrecked)
You're doing it. Right now. I am
screaming at you in the middle of
nowhere and you are somewhere else
even now.

The camera drifts closer to him. He almost turns his cheek
to it.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Say my name.

JAMES
Maya...

MAYA
You had to find me first. You
looked for me. In our own life, you
had to look.

Silence. And then she says the quiet thing. The one she has
been circling all night.

MAYA (CONT'D)
(no anger left, which is
worse)
You could put it down, you know.
Whatever it is you carry around in
here. You could set it down and
turn around and just be here, in
the room, with me.

JAMES
It isn't that simple.

MAYA
It's exactly that simple. That's
the part that kills me. And you
won't. Because if you ever put it
down you wouldn't know who you were
without it. You'd just be a man
standing in a kitchen with his
wife. And that frightens you more
than I ever could.

He doesn't deny it. He can't. That silence is the whole
answer.

Then he comes at her. Fast. Not gentle. A collision. He
grabs her. She shoves him hard in the chest, then fists his
shirt and hauls him back in. Rage and want, no daylight
between them.

She bites his shoulder. Hard. He makes a sound. He holds her
by the arms, too tight, his face turned away over her head,
his eyes open. Finding the space.

JAMES
(breaking, into her hair)
I am trying. You have no idea how
hard I am trying.

MAYA
(into his chest, savage)
Trying to what. To stay? You can't
even do that.

His eyes fix on the empty air where the camera hovers.
Something goes out of his face.

He lets go of her. Steps back.

MAYA (CONT'D)
What. What is it.

JAMES
No.

MAYA
(rising, frightened now)
James. Look at me. What is it.

He is not looking at her. He steps back again, into the room, and his hand comes up. Reaching toward the nothing beside him. Palm open. At a height. As if to find a shoulder that should be there.

His fingers an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. What he is doing. The reach. The two mugs. The dead-cold cup. The window he keeps opening. The whole shape of the evening laid out like evidence against him.

His face comes apart.

JAMES
(barely)
No.

His arm sweeps the side table. The cold mug hits the floor and smashes.

MAYA
(flinching back)
James.

He is not looking at her. He is looking at the empty air. He backs away from it, and it follows him, gentle, closer, not understanding.

JAMES
(low, pleading, to no one
she can see)
Not tonight. Not now. Go.

MAYA
(barely a whisper)
Who are you talking to.

JAMES
(a roar, ragged, at
nothing at all)
FUCK OFF!

The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS. A hard rush back, away from him, across the room, over the broken mug, out through the gap in the window.

EXT. COTTAGE / FELLS - CONTINUOUS

Out into the cold and UP. Fast. Climbing hard. The gold window shrinking beneath it.

The mountains. The dark. All that empty country.

It stops, high above the roof. Looks down.

Down at the little lit cottage. Down at the one warm window with the man in it. Small now. Both hands over his face.

And Maya, frozen behind him. Staring at the man she loves screaming at an empty room, a smashed cup at his feet, and nothing there. Nothing at all.

The camera holds in the dark. Tilted down. The way you look back at a place you have just been thrown out of.

The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.